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Peer Influence and Parental Support as Determinants of Anti-Social Behavior among Undergraduate Students in Selected Nigerian Universities

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Abstract

The study investigated peer influence and parental support as determinants of anti-social behavior among undergraduate students in selected Nigerian universities. The sudden increase in the anti-social behavior which includes smoking of hemps, kidnapping, rape, bullying, examination misconduct, etc. prompted the rationale for carrying out a study that would delve into such activities by considering some likely factors responsible for it. Survey design was used and data was collected using simple random sampling technique of data collection. The participants were 150 students of 77 male (51.33%) and 73 female (48.66%) in that sequence. The parenting styles scale, self-reported anti-social behavior scale and deviant peers scale were used as instruments for data collection. Four hypotheses were adequately tested using *independent samples t-test*, linear regression and Pearson Product Moment Correlation (PPMC). It was found that peers influence and parental support had significant influence on anti-social behavior and that there was gender difference on anti-social behavior among undergraduate students in selected universities in Nigeria. Universities should maintain a unit responsible for behaviour modification, parents and other authority figures in the universities should be apt in discovering students that put up anti-social acts such as stealing, examination misconduct, non-compliance with basic rules, lying and other misconducts within and outside the university premises, activities on campus that could result in anti-social behaviour through peers' influence should be discouraged and there is need for parents to closely monitor their children and wards against any perceived behaviour that is anti-social in nature.

Keywords: Peer Influence, Parental Support, Anti-social Behavior.

INTRODUCTION

Behaviorism is an aspect of psychology known as behavioral psychology which avers that behaviors are learned on the basis of the interaction with the individual's environment with the use of a process called conditioning (Mcleod, 2017). Therefore, behavior can be seen as an individual's response to the stimuli in the environment. In essence, behaviorism is more interested in behaviors that can be observed. It is a stimulus-response approach, whereby some factors are responsible for a particular course of action. According to J. B. Watson in Mcleod (2017), behaviorists view issues in an objective experimental approach with the application of natural with the main aim of ensuring the prediction and control of the stimuli.

In behavioral psychology, two essential central concepts are operant and classical conditioning (Susman, 2020). The major behaviorists were B.F. Skinner, Ivan Pavlov and J.B. Watson. Both operant and classical conditioning result in learning and behavioral change, though they both work differently. Operant conditioning is related to voluntary behavior which produces a consequence, while classical conditioning is connected with involuntary response and a stimulus. Classical conditioning involves the creation of a link between a stimulus that exists naturally (e.g. food) and a neutral stimulus (e.g. sounding a bell). The unconditioned stimulus (US) results in the salivation which is responding to the food called unconditioned response (UR). After the object has gotten used to the sound of the bell to pairing of food, the sound of the bell alone will naturally evoke a response to salivate (Susman, 2020). The sound of the bell alone without pairing food is conditioned stimulus (CS) and the response that follows is conditioned response (CR).

Operant conditioning is also known as instrumental conditioning, which is primarily concerned with punishment or reinforcement that culminate in increase or decrease in a particular behavior. In this light, there is a link between the behavior that is elicited and the consequence of the behavior (Dunsmoor and Murphy, 2015). In operant conditioning, incentives are often given to the learner, while in classical conditioning; such inducement is absent (Silverman et al, 2016). Classical conditioning is passive from the learner's perspective, but operant conditioning demands active participation of the learner in carry out some particular action so as to be

punished or rewarded. At this juncture, this study investigated anti-social behavior among undergraduate students in the selected Nigerian universities, focusing on factors in the environment such as parental support and peer influence as determinants of anti-social behavior.

Every society has its acceptable and established social behavioral standard that allows individual to peacefully co-exist in a community. Any deviation from this standard is referred to as antisocial behavior. Antisocial behavior is define as a self-serving behavior that infringes social norms, lacks the interest of others and may results in a colossal impairment to the society, which might be intentional or through negligence. Antisocial behavior describes all behaviors, attitudes and traits that are dysfunctional engaged by people which lead to negative interpersonal and societal outcomes (Ogwuche *et al*., 2018). It is a self-centred behavior resulting in the violation of zero consideration for others and social norms, culminating in societal damage, which could occur through negligence or intentionally. It is behaving in ways that result in injury or distress to some certain members of the society. Anti-social behavior is seen as the behavior that contradicts acceptable social norms and injures other people's rights (Pena and Grana, cited in Alvarez-Garcia, 2019). A lot of people put up this kind of behavior as they grow in life. Although this does not usually occur and takes place in some specific circumstances. Undergraduate students in the universities who are mostly within the adolescent stage are highly susceptible to anti-social behavior. Occasionally, most of these students display anti-social behavior in order to give room for social identity and status improvement in the campus. Anti-social behavior is a stable feature that continues till the stage of an adult (Moffitt cited in Alvarez-Garcia, 2019).

Also, any behavior that violates social norms and abuses the right of others is referred to as antisocial behavior. This anomalous behavior is exhibited by many people at various stages of their lives. Students are most especially prone to antisocial behavior since this is a stage of youthful exuberance as they seek to experiment with life which in turn contributes to the formation of livelong personal identity. Students who exhibit antisocial behaviors make life miserable for people around them. Therefore, any action that does not consider or lack the overall well-being of others is referred to as antisocial behavior (Mash and Wolfe, 2016)

Antisocial behavior results to detrimental personal and social harm such as reduced education or work opportunities, unstable behaviors in adulthood, mental health issues and legal consequences. Students affected by antisocial behaviors may suffer social, physical, emotional or economic consequences (Cook *et al*., 2015, Sawyer *et al*., 2015). Antisocial behaviors among students are behavioral disorder which includes assault, vandalism, setting fires, theft, thuggery, crime, bullying, not attending classes, staying away from schools and homes, truant, vandalism, rape, sex, pornography, impulsiveness, psychological and physical aggression, manipulating others, smoking, occultism, stubbornness, abusive/insulting behaviors and reckless disregard for self and others. These maladaptive behaviors if left uncurtail will persist and worsen in severity over time becoming a long-lasting behavioral disorder (Ojo, 2015).

Anti-social behavior has produced both social and personal harm to human existence. Students who partake in anti-social behavior have the tendency of confronting work and educational privileges, culminating in neurotic behaviors, mental illness and ultimately legal penalties during adulthood. The victims of anti-social behaviors experience economic, physical and emotional consequences (Cook et al., 2015). The resource that consequences of anti-social behavior gulp is monumental especially in the areas of juvenile justice system, education and mental health (Sawyer et al., 2015). For behavior to be anti-social, it must be consistently causing harm to the point of causing discomfort to the society (Ogwuche et al, 2018).

There are different indicators that cause anti-social behavior. Some of these factors include family related factors such as parental support (Nisar, Ullah, Alli and Alam, 2015). Parental support has been found as a consistent factor causing anti-social behavior because bringing up children is a herculean task and in order to effectively raise children, parents often times support the behavior of their children.

The potential risk factors that could culminate in anti-social behavior are classified into four broad groups: temperamental/individual (such as level of intelligence quotient), social and environmental (such as peers, neighbourhood and family), course modifiers (such as adopting anti-social behavior at the early stage and co-morbidity with some other disorders), physiological and genetic factors such as family history (Gardner, et al, 2015). Albeit, these factors are peculiar to both male and female students as causes of anti-social behavior, it is believed that some

specific factors that could result in anti-social behavior are gender-specific (Urben, et al, 2016). Girls develop symptoms of depression as a way of creating bond with their mothers (Urben et al, 2016).

Failure of student to comply with the standards and norms of the social environment either at home or school makes antisocial behavior inevitable. Most at times, students who exhibit antisocial behaviors look pleasant and innocent, but often hurt others and feel little or no regret due to their activities. A number of environmental factors are the main reasons that contribute towards the development of unsociable behaviors including parents, peers, and school which influence the wholesome development of a child, in terms of physical, affective, social, and spiritual (Khaliq and Rasool, 2019).

The behavior of children is often impacted by the practices of their parents (Ruiz-Hernández et al., 2019). Parenting styles are categorized into two basic forms, and these are, demandingness and responsiveness (Maccoby and Martin, cited in Alvarez-Garcia, 2019). The positive steps parents often take in influencing their children are developing close relationship, constant communication and support at all levels and these are cardinal for their development. The influence of parents on the children tends to be higher than that of the peers; however, there is a decline in family influence as friends' influence increases (Alvarez-Garcia, 2019). Research has shown that anti-social friendships are notable risk determinants of non-violent and violent anti-social behavior (Cutrín et al., 2017). Parents exert significant influence on their children with regards to the kinds of friends they keep. In essence, adequate monitoring by the parents is an effective factor protecting the children against deviant peers (Cutrín et al., 2015). The establishment of warmth and communicative atmosphere with the children by parents would make them inform their parents about the things going on in their lives, especially what they embark upon (Álvarez-García et al., 2016).

Peers are essential agents of socialization in childhood till adulthood with regards to anti-social behavior (Snyder et. al, cited in Sijtsemaa and Lindenbergb, 2018). The more youths grow, the more intimate the level of peer relationship (Hartup cited in Sijtsemaa and Lindenbergb, 2018) and the behavior of peers are seen as the standard for the establishment of rewarding behaviors which could either be anti-social or not (Steinberg cited in Sijtsemaa and Lindenbergb, 2018). It

has been observed in students, especially those in the universities, a growing proportion of anti-social behavior which might be due to two factors. First, there is high prevalence of anti-social behavior among the adolescents students in the universities and secondly, peers perform a cardinal role in the lives of the university students.

According to the Moffitt's theory of taxonomy of life course, students were dichotomized into consistent and limited anti-social behavior and it was found that the students that display limited anti-social behavior put up a transient increase in anti-social behavior as a result of the difference between social and biological maturity which is called "maturity gap" (Moffitt cited in Sijtsemaa and Lindenbergb, 2018). The gap thus results in some specific tension or strain in the body of the student culminating in the students displaying their autonomy and maturity with the use of mature behaviors that involve anti-social and risky behavior like smoking, delinquency and drinking alcoholics (Sijtsemaa and Lindenbergb, 2018: Omopo, 2023). That is, the more students try to block the maturity gap the more it becomes normative and higher level of anti-social behavior. In the university students, anti-social behavior is basically instrumental for the close of the maturity gap and a suitable way for the attainment peer group status and autonomy (Hawley cited in Sijtsemaa and Lindenbergb, 2018).

The central theme of Moffitt's theory is that social influence or imitation is the basic way by which these students learn anti-social behavior. That is students learn anti-social behavior by watching other students display these behaviors on a regular basis (Sijtsemaa and Lindenbergb, 2018). It is worthy of note that different students' contexts exert different behavioral influence on the students based on what the students value or appreciate in a given context. Studies that focused on anti-social behavior and brain development showed the region of the brain that is linked to the increase of reward in the students (Chein et al., cited in Sijtsemaa and Lindenbergb, 2018). Essentially, these brain regions become activated in the social settings where peer status is vital (Sommerville, cited in Sijtsemaa and Lindenbergb, 2018). Therefore, when these students are with their colleagues, peers and school mates, they display behaviors that would raise their position at the social gathering. Based on the fact that anti-social behaviors are normative and are linked with a high and mature social status, there is increased tendency for these behaviors to be imitated by other students (Bandura cited in Sijtsemaa and Lindenbergb, 2018). Therefore, students that put up anti-social behavior become the reference group among other students,

especially when they have the strategy for effective combination of pro-social and anti-social behaviors (Hawley cited in Sijtsemaa and Lindenbergb, 2018). In the event that such behaviors become unapproved by the parents and lecturers, this could reinforce the students to engage more in anti-social behavior as a way of testifying their mature and autonomous status as youths.

Dishion, Patterson, and Griesler cited in Sijtsemaa and Lindenbergb, (2018) developed a theory on peer processes' role and development of anti-social behavior. The theorists introduced confluence as a concept for the description of how characteristics of adolescents which include anti-social behavior grow within the friendship context in relation to peer rejection and acceptance, friends' initial selection, peer influence within some categories of friends using the processes of peer reinforcement which include talking in a deviant way. According to the researchers, anti-social youths could be up against peer group rejection leaving them with few friends to choose from. Thus, anti-social youths have the tendency of seeking out other peers with anti-social personality available to become their friends. Consequently, anti-social peers have the capacity to influence other youths with anti-social behavior using deviancy training process (Dishion and Tipsord, cited in Sijtsemaa and Lindenbergb, 2018). The process has to do with an alteration in the course of deviant values and attitudes because specific rewards are attached to these changes in social interactions. In view of this, peers tend to secretly and apparently encourage anti-social behavior and can decide to showcase anti-social behavior in order to be suitable for a major position within the peer group.

Another theory explaining anti-social behavior is coercion theory which opines that family social processes is a way of enlightening the youth on the benefit of anti-social behavior as a way of making one having his way within the family setting (Petterson cited in Sijtsemaa and Lindenbergb, 2018). In students, this is more related to the parental support for anti-social behavior, as some attitude display by the parents, like refusing to provide the basic necessity for the student as a way of punishing them could reinforce in the student some anti-social behavior such as stealing and keeping friends that have related conducts (Snyder et al. cited Sijtsemaa and Lindenbergb, 2018).

Objectives of the Study

The broad objective of the study was to investigate peer influence and parental support as determinants of anti-social behavior among undergraduate students in selected Nigerian universities. The specific objectives of the study are as follows:

i. To determine the relationship between peer influence, parental support and anti-social behavior among undergraduate students in selected Nigerian universities.
ii. To examine the relative influence of peer influence and parental support on anti-social behavior among undergraduate students in selected Nigerian universities.
iii. To ascertain the joint influence of peer influence and parental support on anti-social behavior among undergraduate students in selected Nigerian universities.
iv. To determine the gender difference on anti-social behavior among undergraduate students in selected Nigerian universities.

Research Hypotheses

The following research hypotheses were tested in this study:

i. There will be significant relationship between peer influence, parental support and anti-social behavior among undergraduate students in selected Nigerian universities.
ii. There will be significant joint influence of peer influence and parental support on anti-social behavior among undergraduate students in selected Nigerian universities.
iii. There will be significant relative influence of peer influence and parental support on anti-social behavior among undergraduate students in selected Nigerian universities.
iv. There will be significant gender difference on anti-social behavior among undergraduate students in selected Nigerian universities.

METHODS

The research employed a descriptive research design to investigate the relationship between various parenting techniques and their effects on university students in Nigeria through their

anti-social behavior and peer relationships. The study included 150 participants who were 77 males and 73 females with a mean age of 19.08 (SD = 2.64) for males and 16.07 (SD = 4.05) for females. Researchers selected participants through random selection from various universities which included Bale University Abuja, University of Ibadan, Elizade University, Adekunle Ajasin University, University of Nigeria, Nsukka, and Ahmadu Bello University. The researchers collected data through a Google Forms online questionnaire which protected participant safety during the COVID-19 pandemic. The survey included three scales which included the Parenting Styles Scale and the Anti-Social Behavior Scale and the Deviant Peers Scale. The Parenting Styles Scale assessed parental monitoring and control through its measurement of parental monitoring and control according to the adaptation from Olivia et al. (2007). The Anti-Social Behavior Scale used Álvarez-García et al. (2019) as its basis to evaluate theft and property destruction behaviors. The Deviant Peers Scale used 14 items to measure the impact of peer groups on anti-social behavior among youths.

The researcher obtained research permission from selected universities before collecting data while obtaining informed consent from participants who needed to understand their participation rights and response confidentiality was also collected. The researcher sent a unique link to each participant after they obtained consent through email and WhatsApp for online questionnaire access. Participants needed to complete the survey without assistance before they could send their answers through the provided link. The responses were collected and saved for analysis purposes. The researchers used descriptive statistics to summarize the data through means and standard deviations. The researchers used inferential statistics to explore how different variables related to each other by using t-tests for independent samples to study gender differences and using Pearson Product Moment Correlation (PPMC) to measure variable associations and using regression analysis for predictive relationship outcomes. The data analysis served to investigate how parenting methods and peer influence together with anti-social behavior related to each other while providing understanding into the behavior patterns observed in Nigerian university students.

Results and Discussion

Hypothesis One

The first hypothesis states that there is significant relationship between peer influence, parental support and anti-social behavior among undergraduate students in selected Nigerian universities.

Table 1: Zero Order Correlation Matrix Showing Relationship between peer influence, parental support and anti-social behavior of Undergraduate Students

S/N	Variable	1	2	3	$\bar{X}$	SD
1	Anti-Social Beh.	-			17.61	3.73
2	Peer Influence	.187*	-		21.92	4.70
6	Parental Support	.305**	.034	-	18.97	4.19

** Correlation is significant (P<0.01) *Correlation is significant (P<0.05)

Table 1 indicates that peer influence had significant relationship with undergraduate students' anti-social behavior r=0.187, p<.05), parental support (r=0.305, p<.01). Thus, there is relationship between parental support, peer influence and anti-social behavior of undergraduate students in the selected Nigerian universities. This was consistent with the findings of the findings of Sijtsemaa and Lindenbergb, (2018) that peer pressure had significant correlation with anti-social behavior and that different behaviors influence how adolescent behave in social interactions. This implies that the more students expose to different behaviors that is not in line with acceptable social standards in their campuses, the more anti-social they become. Those that have less interaction with anti-social students are unlikely to display anti-social behavior. This indicates therefore that students with pro-social behavior have higher number of friends that engage in acts that are within the acceptable norms of the society. Nisar, et al, (2015) opines that parental support has been a consistent factor inciting anti-social behavior among the youths. In essence, students whose parents do things that promote anti-social behavior in them are more prone to act in unacceptable ways. For instance, permissive parents, who allow their wards to carry out any task of their choice without restraint (smoking, drinking alcohol, promiscuity, etc.) are ultimately bringing out the anti-social tendency in their children. This is because when such children become admitted into the university, they will be more attracted to other students with similar conduct or behavior.

Hypothesis Two

The second hypothesis investigates significant joint influence of peer influence and parental support on anti-social behavior among undergraduate students in selected Nigerian universities.

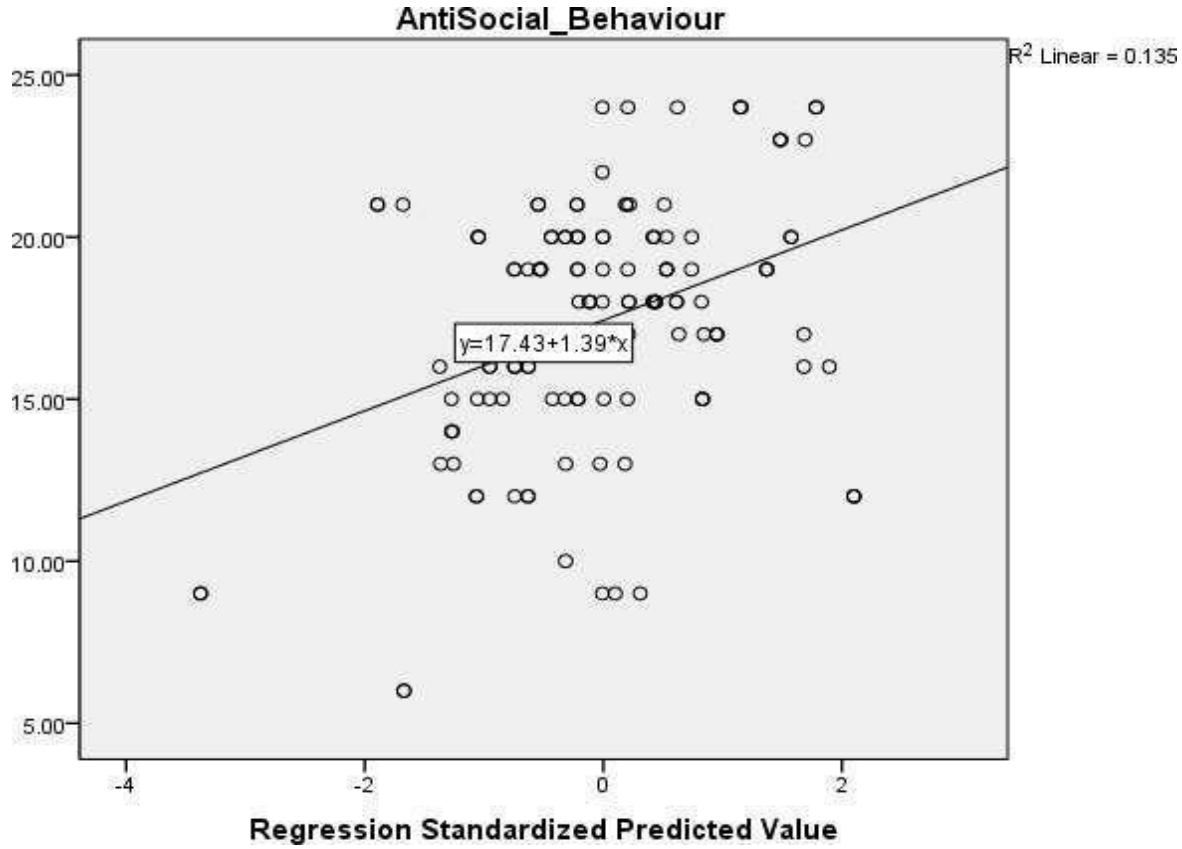
Table 2: Summary of Regression analysis showing the Joint Influence of Peer Influence and Parental support on Anti-social Behavior among Undergraduate Students in Selected Nigerian universities

R	**R Square**			**Adjusted R Square**	**Std. Error of the Estimate**	
.367	.135			.122	3.559	
A N O V A						
Model	**Sum of Squares**	**DF**	**Mean Square**	**F**	**Sig.**	**Remark**
Regression Residual Total	260.762 1672.319 1933.061	2 132 134	130.381 12.669	10.291	.000	Sig.

Table 2 indicates the joint influence of peer influence and parental support on anti-social behavior among undergraduate students in selected Nigerian universities (R = .367 and R^2 = .135 and adjusted R^2 = .122). This connotes that peer influence and parental support made a joint contribution of 13.5% to anti-social behavior of the undergraduate students in selected Nigerian universities. The joint influence was tested at significant value of 0.05. The result further depicts an F-ratio of 10.291, $P< 0.05$. This depicts a significant joint contribution of peer influence and parental support on anti-social behavior of undergraduate students in selected Nigerian universities. The finding of this study is further shown in the figure 1. The finding of this study was refuted by Ogwuche et al, (2018) who aver parental support as not having any significant influence on students' anti-social behavior. However, based on the present study, parental support was seen as having substantial influence on anti-social behavior among the students. This shows that for a student to display anti-social behavior in the school, he must have been receiving substantial support from the home. It could be that the parents of the students involved have been highly authoritarians, who never listen to the views of their children, but make sure that it is whatever they want that the children do. Such children become dejected and tend to seek acceptance else by looking for peers who would make them feel good. Such children when they gain admission into the university tend to engage in cultism and other acts that are against the societal norms.

Ruiz-Hernández et al., (2019) opine that children's behaviors are often influence by their parents. This depicts that parents that have anti-social behavior would ultimately produce children with similar personality problem. Good parenting style is important, as responsive parents win the heart of their wards towards developing close friendship with other students who display pro-social behavior and avoid those with anti-social behavior.

Figure 1 shows the joint influence of peer influence and parental support on anti-social behaviour among Undergraduate Students in Selected Nigerian universities



Hypothesis Three

The third hypothesis states that there is significant relative influence of peer influence and parental support on anti-social behavior among undergraduate students in selected Nigerian universities.

Table 3: Summary of regression analysis showing the Relative Influence of Peer Influence and Parental support on Anti-social Behavior among Undergraduate Students in Selected Nigerian universities

Model		Unstandardized Coefficients		Standardized Coefficients	t	Sig.
		B	Std. Error	Beta		
1	(Constant)	8.595	2.031		4.233	.000
	Peer_Influence	.149	.065	.185	2.285	.024
	Parental_Support	.292	.075	.314	3.874	.000

a. Dependent Variable: AntiSocial_Behavior

Table 3 depicts the relative influence of peer influence and parental support on anti-social behavior; parental support (β =.314, t = 3.874 P<.05), peer influence (β = .185, t = .2.285 P<.05) in that sequence. This shows therefore that there is significant relative influence of parental support and peer influence on anti-social behavior among undergraduate students in selected Nigerian universities. This was in contrast to the findings of Ogwuche et al, (2018) that parental support did not have significant influence on students' anti-social behavior. However, the finding of this study was consistent with that of Sijtsemaa and Lindenbergb, (2018) and Omopo (2024) who both posit that peer influence had significant impact on anti-social behavior among adolescents. Therefore, the extent to which peers exert pressure on others towards engaging in behaviors that are not approved by the normal standard of behavior in the society is very high.

Hypothesis Four

The fourth hypothesis states that there is significant gender difference on anti-social behavior among undergraduate students in selected Nigerian universities

Table 4: Summary of independent t-test table showing Gender Difference on Anti-social Behavior among undergraduate students of selected Nigerian universities

Gender	N	Mean	SD	Df	T	P
Male	77	19.078	2.694	148	5.388	<.01
Female	73	16.069	4.046			

Table 4 depicts that a significant gender difference exists on anti-social behavior among undergraduate students in selected Nigerian universities [$t(148) = 5.388$; $p<.01$]. The result further shows that male students exhibited higher mean difference ($\bar{x}=19.078$) compared with the female students that had lower mean difference ($\bar{x}=16.069$). This was consistent with the findings of Coelho, Neves and Caridade (2020) found a significant gender difference on anti-social behavior, with male participants displaying higher level of risk to anti-social behavior compared to female participants with lower risk level. This shows that male students have the inherent capacity to engage in behaviors that are not in tune with the acceptable standard rule of behavior in the campus. Male students are more prone to engaging in friendship that could lure them into anti-social behavior such as bullying, smoking, robbery, carousing, etc.

Conclusion

Anti-social behaviour of the undergraduate students in selected Nigerian universities has been the major bane of moral degradation in the campuses and the society at large. The negative consequences of anti-social behavior is the major reason why some students find it difficult to come to terms with the norms of behavior within the university setting and the society at large. This study has delved into the influence of parental support, gender and peers on anti-social behavior within the university setting.

The researcher has been able to draw the conclusion subject to the findings of this study that gender has significant influence on anti-social behaviour, with more male participants having the tendency of indulging in anti-social behaviour than the female participants. It was further found that parental support and peers influence had significant influence on anti-social behavior of the undergraduate students. In terms of relative influence, parental support was found to exert higher significant independent influence on anti-social behavior followed by peers influence.

Parental support and peers influence have been proven in this study to be the potent factors influencing anti-social behavior among the undergraduate students. Although there are several factors that could result in anti-social behavior, but one of the humajor determinants of anti-social behaviors are gender, peers influence and parental support.

Recommendations

In view of the findings of this study, the researcher made the following recommendations:

1. Universities should maintain a unit responsible for behaviour modification. This unit should have behaviour and counselling psychologist as its head, which shall be responsible for helping students with anti-social behaviour develop good and society acceptable standard of behaviour.
2. Parents and other authority figures in the universities should be apt in discovering students that put up anti-social acts such as stealing, examination misconduct, non-compliance with basic rules, lying and other misconducts within and outside the university premises.
3. Activities on campus that could result in anti-social behaviour through peers' influence should be discouraged. This could be done by ensuring all hide-outs that encourage nefarious activities on campus such as cultism, hooliganism and armed robbery should be dismantled.
4. There is need for parents to closely monitor their children and wards against any perceived behaviour that is anti-social in nature. This is by first making sure that parents are good examples in moral, character and conduct to their children in all things.

Limitations of the Study

The study was limited by finance and time. The financial paucity and time did not give the researcher enough opportunity to expand the scope of the study beyond six universities across Nigeria. The mode of data collection which was strictly online due to the covid-19 pandemic for safety reasons, made the number of participants to be low. The covid-19 pandemic that necessitated online questionnaire administration using Google forms faced a lot of restrictions from the would-be participants, who initially did not want to participate in the study, until further persuasion.

Suggestion for Further Studies

The researcher suggests that more studies be conducted in the future on anti-social behaviour using other group of people or considering other predictors other than parental support and peers influence.

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